THE REVISED CELAN PHONETIC GUIDE

A structured reference to consonant shifts, vowel systems, phonetic couplings, and pronunciation registers.

About this guide

Celan pronunciation combines stable vowel anchors with flexible consonant and vowel pairings. Several pronunciations are equally valid, allowing pronunciation to vary by dialect, mood, musical style, and speaking register. This report preserves the phonetic examples and usage guidance in the revised reference.

> **Core principle**
> Variation is part of the language: **W** may sound like W or V; **X** may sound like KH or KS anywhere in a word; **ae** may take three forms; and **th** may be flowing or sharply aspirated.

1. The Shifting Consonants: W, X, and TH

1.1 The letter W: the “W” vs. “V” shift

The letter **W** has two valid sounds depending on the speaker’s dialect, mood, or musical style.

Pronunciation	Articulation and register	Examples
Flowing W (soft approximant)	Pronounced like the standard English *w* in *water* or *wind*.	**Wek** → Wehk (cycle) **Wel** → Wehl (communal share) **Woreth** → Wohr-ehth (abundant)
Firm V (voiced fricative)	Pronounced like the German/Slavic *v*, with the teeth touching the lower lip. Very common in northern or martial accents (Valkeldor/Mechuma), or with sharp emphasis.	**Wek** → Vehk **Wel** → Vehl **Worvenak** → Vor-veh-nahk

1.2 The letter X: “KH” vs. “KS” fluidity

X is not locked to word positions. It may be pronounced as **KH** or **KS** anywhere, including at the beginning of a word.

Pronunciation	Articulation	Examples
Guttural / breathy KH ([x])	A textured throat scrape, like the Scottish *ch* in *loch* or Spanish *j*.	**Xar** → Khar (shelter / cover) **Xaresh** → Khar-esh (cloak) **Xilvar** → Kheel-var (hidden spice) **Dralxar** → Dral-khar (eclipse)
Crisp / percussive KS ([ks])	A sharp modern English *x* sound, like *box* or *extra*. It may validly start a word.	**Xar** → Ksar **Xaresh** → Ksar-esh **Xilbren** → Kseel-brehn **Dralxar** → Dral-ksar

> **Style note**
> A poetic or ancient singer may lean into the breathy **KH** sound (*Khar*). A fast-talking city merchant or sharp pop vocalist may prefer the crisp snap of **KS** (*Ksar*). Both are fully correct.

1.3 The coupling TH: soft dental vs. sharp aspirated

Pronunciation	Articulation	Examples
Flowing TH (soft dental)	English th in think is voiceless; in this it is voiced. Both are valid.	**Thar** → Thahr (heart) **Thal** → Thahl (balance)
Martial T-HA (sharp and aspirated)	The tongue strikes the teeth with a firm **T**, followed by a distinct puff of air, **H** (“t-ha”).	**Thar** → T-hahr **Thal** → T-hahl

2. Vowel Couplings: Glides and Diphthongs

2.1 The ae coupling

The **ae** pairing has three accepted realizations. The chosen form depends on pace, register, and performance style.

Sound option	Preferred setting	Pronunciation examples
Ah-eh Two beats	Sacred decrees, slow hymns, and high ceremonial poetry.	**Aen** → Ah-ehn **Rinaen** → Ree-nah-ehn **Vael** → Vah-ehl
Ay As in “day”	Fast dialogue, pop songs, and casual speech.	**Aen** → Ayn **Rinaen** → Ree-nayn **Vael** → Vayl
Eye As in “sky”	Fast dialogue, pop songs, and casual speech.	A valid bright alternative for **ae**.

2.2 The ai coupling

ai is pronounced **"Eye"**, a bright diphthong. This form is universal across all registers.

Coupling	Sound	Examples
ai	"Eye" (bright diphthong)	**Aiv** → Eyev (pain) **Rinaen-ai** → Ree-nayn-eye

2.3 The oa coupling

oa may sound like **"Oh-ah"** or **"Wah"**. The transition varies with speaking speed.

Coupling	Sound options	Example
oa	"Oh-ah" or "Wah"	**Doa** → Doh-ah or Dwah

3. The Anchor Vowels: Single Vowels

Single vowels remain pure, open, and resonant in the Italian / Spanish style.

Vowel	Sound	Reference word	Celan example
A	"Ah"	father	**Terra** → TEHR-rah
E	"Eh"	bed	**Dren** → Drehn
I	"Ee"	machine	**Ilin** → EE-leen
O	"Oh"	go	**Morl** → Morl
U	"Oo"	flu	**Zun** → Zoon

4. Other Key Couplings and Digraphs

Coupling	Sound and articulation	Examples
SH	**Soft sibilant.** Standard English *sh* as in *shine*.	**Shal** (Shahl) **Shara** (Shah-rah)
ZH	**Voiced sibilant.** Like the *s* in *measure* or *vision*.	**Zhir** (Zheer) **Zhael** (Zhay-el)
KH	**Deep guttural.** Rough back-of-the-throat scrape.	**Khumlor** (Khoom-lor) **Khelu** (Khay-loo)

5. The Ancient Prenasal Starters: MB-, ND-, NK-

Hum the nasal letter for a fraction of a second before releasing the consonant. The nasal sound should lead directly into the next beat.

Starter	Articulation	Celan example
MB-	Hum with lips closed, then release into **B**.	**Mbalan** = m-BAH-lahn (pillar)
ND-	Hum with tongue on the roof of the mouth, then release into **D**.	**Ndem** = n-DEHM (blood)
NK-	Hum at the back of the throat, then strike **K**.	**Nkuvath** = n-KOO-vahth (sacred trust)

6. Standard Single Consonants

Letters	Pronunciation guidance
B, D, G, V, Z	Voiced, firm, and resonant.
K, T, P	Sharp, clean stops; never swallowed.
L, R	Flowing liquids. **R** is lightly tapped or rolled at the front of the mouth.
M, N	Clear nasal tones.
J	Soft, gliding like French *j* / “Zh”. Example: **Joreth** = Zhor-eth.

The Universal Pronunciation Summary

- **X** can be “Kh” **or** “Ks” anywhere in the word (**Xar** = Khar or Ksar).
- **W** can be soft “W” **or** firm “V” (**Wek** = Wehk or Vehk).
- **ae** can be stately “Ah-eh”, smooth “Ay”, or bright “Eye”.
- **th** can be flowing (think: voiceless; this: voiced) or sharply aspirated (t-ha).
- **mb / nd / nk** begin with a quick hum into the beat.

End of reference report.